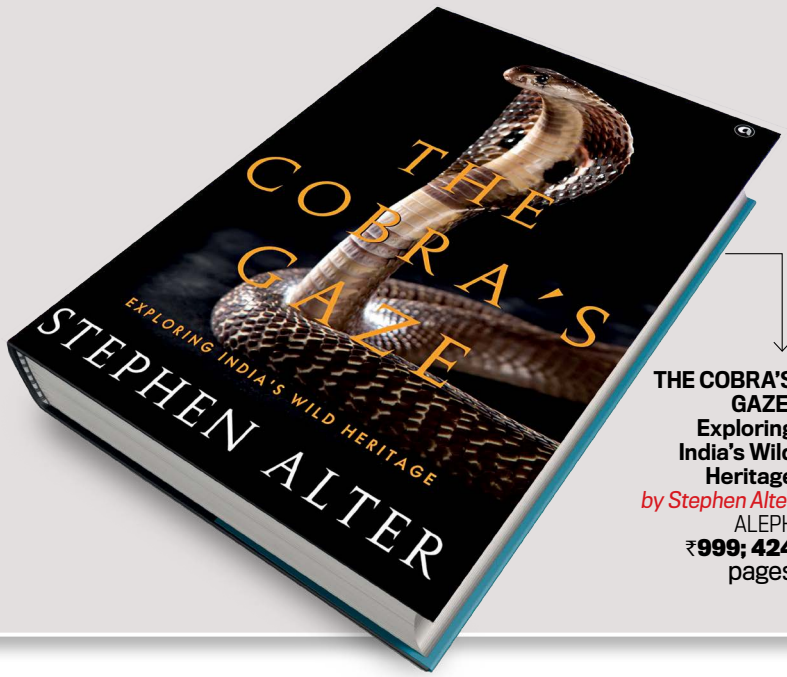
BOOKS

WALKS ON THE WILD SIDE

PART TRAVELOGUE AND PART INQUIRY, **STEPHEN ALTER'S** *THE COBRA'S GAZE* URGES INDIANS TO CONNECT DEEPER WITH NATURE AMIDST OUR ONGOING WAR AGAINST WILDLIFE



THE COBRA'S GAZE: Exploring India's Wild Heritage
by Stephen Alter
ALEPH
₹999; 424 pages

In *The Cobra's Gaze*, Stephen Alter returns with another slow-burning tour de force, drawing on journeys in the Indian subcontinent to revisit the human connection with nature. Offering cultural and historical context to our ongoing struggle to preserve wildlife, the Indian-born American author urges us to meet the gaze of creatures that are looking at us, perhaps for answers.

Written in his characteristic style that melds natural history inquiry with a seeker's travelogue, it spotlights a tribe of modern Indian naturalists and conservationists, placing their work in context with that of pioneering forebears like Sálim Ali, M. Krishnan, Billy Arjan Singh and Jim Corbett.

Tellingly, the book starts at the beginning of remembered time in the subcontinent. At Bhimbetka, near Bhopal, where the 10,000-year-old cave art of early human settlers records the extant fauna, Alter is struck by the picturisation of central Indian forests teeming with wildlife. Walking with citizen-scientists in the wooded campus of Bengaluru's Indian Institute of Science, he runs into grey slender lorises and Indian palm civets, nocturnal creatures that inhabit the remnant pockets of darkness in this light-polluted metropolis. Sidling past specimens marinated in formalin-filled jars at the Bombay Natural History Society, the author experiences a burdening sense of loss for India's once-abundant wildlife.

Whether he is trailing sloth bears in Satpura or Asiatic lions in Gir, smooth-coated otters in the riverine islands of the Kaveri or gharials on the banks of the Chambal, Alter produces shimmering accounts of wildlife encounters

BOOKS

WONDER WOMEN

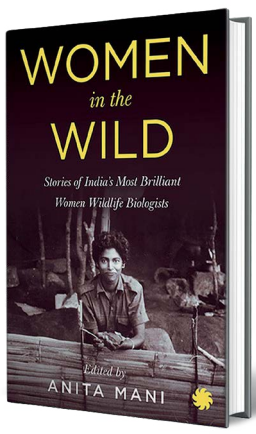
Women in the Wild profiles **pioneering Indian women biologists** and their life in the field

In this wonderful collection, Anita Mani presents the work of 13 wildlife biologists, each of whom has battled sexism, misogyny and the dangers and physical challenges of field research—leeches, scorpions and the occasional pit viper—to further our understanding of our natural world.

The book begins with India's first 'birdwoman', Jamal Ara (1923-95), who, despite being a pioneer of Indian conservation, is virtually unknown. It took wildlife historian Raza Kazmi years of research to track down her daughter, Madhuca Singh and begin to understand her life and legacy.

Kazmi's essay paints a warm, personal portrait of a woman who was not only an ornithologist and conservationist, but also a broadcaster, writer and translator. She also loved flowers, naming her daughter after the mahua tree (*Madhuca indica*) and so entranced by a hillside of *Strobliantheses*—a plant that flowers once a decade—that she declared, "If Wordsworth had seen it, he would have promptly consigned his 'Daffodils' to the ash-can, and written another about the Strobliantheses...."

Next we meet J. Vijaya (1959-87), whose bright, urchin face shines out on the book's cover. Viji was India's first female herpetologist, whose contribution to the understanding and conservation of the cane turtles of south India earned her, many years after her tragically early death, the honour of having a species named after her: *Vijayachelys silvatica*. Her energy and infectious enthusi-



WOMEN IN THE WILD: Stories of India's Most Brilliant Women Wildlife Biologists
Edited by Anita Mani
JUGGERNAUT
₹499; 280 pages